

פרשת וירא. If we look at the פרשה in the context of the parshiyos that surround it, there's a remarkable difference between the three פרשיות of לך לך, וירא, and חיי שרה. The first few words of לך לך are וַיֵּאמֶר ה' אֶל לך. The first three words of חיי שרה are וַיֵּהָיו חַיֵּי שָׂרָה. However, פרשת וירא starts off without mentioning אברהם's name: וַיֵּרָא אֵלָיו ה' בְּאַלְנֵי מְרָא. That's a rather unusual way to start a פרשה. Who are we talking about? We're talking about אברהם. If you go back to the end of לך לך, אברהם's name is not even in the last pasuk, it's in second-to-last pasuk, בְּעֶצֶם הַיּוֹם הַזֶּה נָמוּל אֶבְרָהָם. Then it says וַיֵּרָא אֵלָיו. Why we use a pronoun?

The מנהג, a wonderful ספר which I've quoted many times, brings down a fascinating מנהג, it's not a הלכה, it's a מנהג, that is a rather important thing to know, which I did not know. When a person is visiting a חולה, you should not say his name in his presence. He brings it down from the ילקוט ראובני, quoted in a sefer called סודי רו"א. If someone goes in to visit a חולה, should not mention him by name. He should say רפואה שלמה and ask "How are you? What can I do to help you? Let me help clean up the room a little bit." The רמב"ן writes that it's very important to help keep the place clean and neat, a visitor should make it his business to clean up the house, and that helps the חולה get better. In fact, there's a גמרא in נדרים in גמרא, and people did not come to visit him. מְעַשָּׂה בְּתַלְמִיד אֶחָד מִתְלַמְּדֵי רַבִּי עֲקִיבָא שְׂחָלָה דָּף מִעֲמוּד אֲרַבִּי עָקִיבָא, and he helped to clean him and clean the room, and the sick person said "רַבִּי, הֲיֵיטִיבְתִּי". So there are a number of things you should do on a ביקור חולים visit. But one of the things you don't do is mention his name. And that's exactly what happens here, וַיֵּרָא אֵלָיו. It doesn't say וַיֵּרָא אֶל אברהם to teach you that הקדוש ברוך הוא did not mention his name when he came to visit him.

The מגן אברהם writes in the name of the מהר"ל, a very early פוסק quoted in רש"י many times, that if someone is מבקש רחמים for his friend, you don't have to mention his name while in front of him. But if you're מתפלל while not in front of him, then you should mention his name. And as we all know, we mention the name and the mother's name. The סופר writes, מסכתא נדרים, when a person mentions a חולה's name, there is a התעוררות of דין on him. Therefore, it's a הפסד to mention the sick person's name while in his presence.

Now, he brings another point from the ספר טעמי המנהגים, that another possibility is that there may very well be a גזר against יעקב בן ראובן, so it would be important not to mention his name at a ביקור חולים visit. One of the techniques we have to disrupt that, aside from this one, is to change his name, because that the גזר against יעקב בן ראובן is not the same thing as a גזר against יעקב, for example. So when we change the name, that גזר is no longer applicable to this person because this is a different person with a different name.

Now, another fascinating aspect of this brought down from the Munkatcher Rebbe, the מנחת אלעזר, זכותו יגן, and is mentioned in his number of ספרים of his descendants, is when we make the מי שברך for a חולה in shul, we don't say the word החולה. We say מי שברך אבותינו אברהם יצחק ויעקב הוא יברך את, and the לשון in every סידור says החולה, and then they give the names. Rabbi Oelbaum brought this up a number of years ago and we in our shul changed our מנהג based on this Munkatcher Rebbe to not say the word החולה, we don't want to label this person as a חולה. And brought down in a number of ספרים, which he mentions here one of them is דרכי חיים ושלוה, that Chazal say in מסכת שבת that a person should always be מבקש רחמים that he should not get sick, and if, חס ושלוה, someone does get sick, we say to him, הוי זכות והיפטר - Find a זכות. However, once we label him a חולה, we're being מקיים that that is his status. That's not a זכות, that's cementing him into that category of חולה. Therefore, it's a very excellent suggestion that you can just leave out the word when you say the מי שברך, which we've done in shul for many years. Whoever's גבאי who hears that, you're more than welcome to follow this מנהג or at least bringing it up with your local Orthodox rabbi.



The point being is a person's name is that person. We know that it's a very important ענין when a baby is born to give a name that's appropriate and will be a זכות for him. We don't want that same name חס ושלום to be a חובה to him. Therefore, if חס ושלום a situation happens where someone gets sick, we have to follow these very simple rules, and they will help them have a שלמה רפואה. All the חולים in ישראל should have a געזונט און שטארק and be healthy and stay healthy.

